

Moonsea Rising - 20231008

"Malvolio"

The party finds themselves in a small room. Contained is a statue of a robed figure with a religious symbol around his neck and a sword in his hands. No one recognizes the symbol or the statue, except Beitris who believes it might be a statue of Cyric. The room is 20'x20' with no obvious doors. The sword is not statuary, but rather a real sword with an inscription in an unknown language. The magic pervades the room, with the most powerful being evocation magic. Lennox inspects the sword closely, as Lirael warns him that the magic she detects is likely involved in the creation of energies.

As they search the room, she notices a seam in the wall behind her. Alerting the others that there seems to be a door in the wall, she moves to the corner. As Harken starts fiddling with the door trying to open it, she raises her magical shield. Beitris follows suit, as the others brace for whatever might happen. It silently opens on a 10'x10' hallway that seems to end in the back of another secret door. Lennox moves up to listen at the door. He hears something rhythmic, almost mechanical.

Beitris, meanwhile, looks closer at the inscriptions on the blade. It appears to be written in abyssal, and the best she can do is "out of many circles". She tells Lirael what she's interpreted, and the elf is much disturbed. "I shouldn't like to touch it, but leaving it behind us seems very dangerous." Harken, meanwhile, joins Lennox, but isn't able to hear anything interesting beyond the walls. He warns them they're about to open the door. Taevyn moves up behind them, as Lirael and Beitris hang back against the walls. Harken's paranoia is buzzing, and he triple checks his work on the door before opening. Lennox jumps through as the door opens into...

A greased slope, towards a number of rotating blades! He manages to keep his feet, but that doesn't prevent him sliding down the slope. As everyone looks on in horror, they note that the blades are rotating slowly, but appear to have chopped up a number of goblins in the prior weeks or months, who lie strewn about. The blades aren't moving terribly fast, but there are a lot of them, and they look very sharp. Lennox looks at them and moves around the poles, slowly, assessing. Harken, on the other hand, is looking for controls, and finds a series of buttons with letters associated with them, though their function isn't obvious. Taevyn, much amused, tumbles through the room, avoiding the blades, and sommersaulting out into the next room. He takes a small bow.

Lennox attempts to avoid the blades while chopping at the poles, missing a few swings, but chopping gamely into the poles. They are very hard, and he does little damage. He leaps back out the way they came. Lirael has an idea, and stepping into the room and slipping down the slope. From the ground, she casts tanglefoot, wrapping around the nearest pole and stopping the blades from turning. She calls to the others "this won't hold for long, but I should be able to get us across."

Beitris and Harken slide down, and he navigates the two poles Lirael hasn't immobilized. He leaps up the far side, joining Taevyn on the small ledge adjoining the back of another secret door. Taevyn inspects the door, and then pushes it slightly open. A shout in a guttural but unknown lan-

guage causes him to immediately slam the door closed, as several arrows thud into it. He looks for ways to possibly secure the door, but finding little he draws his rapier. Holding onto the door, he resists as a bugbear attempts to wrench the door back open, but doesn't succeed.

Lennox, seeing all this from across the room, moves back to the statue of Cyric and draws the sword from its hands. It seems magnificent, and he springs back into the chopping floor, as Lirael stands up and stops the next pole from moving. Beitris moves by that pole, and darts around the last one, trying to get up the slope, but slips, getting nicked by the blades. Pulling out her hatchet to use as a climbing axe, she manages to lodge it in the slope, keeping herself in position.

Harken searches in vain for any sign of controls, but nothing leaps out to him. He also draws his rapier and helps Taevyn guard the door. Taevyn calls through the door, "we have a cleric here, and you don't want to be on her bad side!" A murmur runs through the monsters on the other side of the door. On the other side, something repeatedly slams into door. Taevyn opens it, and a goblin goes flying by and down into the pit. Two other goblins are sitting nearby rubbing their heads. Harken slashes at the goblin as it passes, and hitting the blades is the final straw for the smaller creature, who sticks on the blades, dead. The door begins smoking, and Taevyn nervously suggests others come help.

Bellowing at Taevyn to open the door, Lennox charges forward brandishing the sword of the Mad God. He knocks down a goblin on the way, and slashing the nearest goblin with the sword, it screams and its eyes turn an inky purple as its life-force is drained by the accursed sword. The other goblins who were waiting for the door begin stabbing at Lennox with their heinous weapons.

Stepping forward to the next pole she'd stopped, Lirael sends a bolt of searing light into the nearest bugbear, burning him badly. Leaning on her hatchet, Beitris hauls herself to flat ground, and leans back ready to help Lirael. Harken slashes at the bugbear, and flings a large stone from floor with a telekinetic cantrip into him, smashing him back against the wall, as Taevyn comes in with coup de grace, running the bugbear through. The other goblins immediately surrender, seeing the charnel house they've run into in the party.

As Lennox goes to sheathe the weapon, he finds it perfectly pristine and unblemished, with no sign of goblin blood. Beitris and Lirael are pulled up into the room, where the surviving goblins are on their knees in a religious fervor, pointing and prostrating themselves before the sword Lennox is holding. None of them speak goblin, but Lirael tries halfling, which some of them are passable in. They tell them they are waiting for the one who summoned them to this place, and she shall come for them soon. They don't know the way out, but they do know there are dangerous spore around, that are susceptible to fire. They leave the goblins behind and find a room with a large bonfire separating a large number of mushrooms which exude a greenish haze into the air.

Taevyn excitedly asks Lirael if she has any fire spells to clear the spores, but she has nothing particularly of use to this scenario. Taking a flaming chair leg from the bonfire, she steps past it and examines the mushrooms. She finds that the construction on the other side of the bonfire is fine, good enough to be in a castle, but the brackish water running under the bridge seems to be fostering the growth of the mushrooms. They appear to be the kind of dangerous psychodelic fungi one finds in deep swamps. The bridge appears to be newer construction, not fitting with the rest of the construction. It appears that with torches they might keep enough spore away to breathe comfortably, but excessive exposure to the spores would be bad for them.

Taevyn wonders if they should try the door on the other the goblin latrine before risking the spore. He and Lennox slide past the foulness, gagging quietly at the stench. A wooden plaque, partially crumbled away, has some map of the area, with part of a blazon reading "are here." Further down the hallway, the map suggests, are a number of cells and other hallways. The top right corner of the map has the common characters "eep," which he believes might well be "Keep." Beitris notes that the most famous keep in the region would have been Zhentil Keep, before Edric I destroyed the Zhentarim and renamed it. The Zhents were also followers of Cyric, which isn't a great convergence. Lirael wonders if maybe they're beneath Stormreaver Keep, and goes to check the "swamp" running through the cave. The roof above it is dirt, with roots poking through, so they cannot be that far underground.

Harken, having been quietly musing to himself, thinks that maybe the "eep" comes from "Deep," of which there are a number. Combined with the brackishness of the water, he thinks they might be coastal. Given recent connections with Mulmaster, he wonders if maybe they might be under Ironfang or the The Blade's Deep in that region.

Looking down the hallway, it looks as though it is sliced from a building transported below ground, much as the break by the marsh. As Lennox passes Taevyn, he moves towards the Cyric-sword, but Lennox keeps it out of his reach. Beitris is watching Taevyn closely, as this behavior is worrying her.

Harken is still wracking his brain for potential candidates for their present location. He recalls that the city of Phlan was transported to the Nine Hells several centuries back, as well as the great magicks used during the defeat of the Zhentarim by Edric I.

At the end of the hallway is a "room," dug out of the dirt where the hallway ends. A broken coffin lies in the room, with the skeleton that occupied it strewn about. The room looks to have been dug out by claws rather than tools. The coffin appears to have been part of the process of digging out the room. Lirael thinks it was a huge lizard of some kind. Lirael thinks she might be able to dig out, using her insect form. As they're discussing options. Harken isn't sure, but he might be able to hear some earth rumblings to the west. Taevyn wanders down the hallway, and finds more water, with the roof of the dugout area coming down to the surface of the water.

Beneath the water, he hears a roaring sound, as several heads poke up out of the water, and watch him retreat back down the cavern towards the rest of the party.